2E Familars



Elfive
Member

Join Date: Jun 2014
Posts: 8226

06-18-2015, 07:55 AM #46

I think generally Familiars need to be willing anyway.For an angel that's practically synonymous with "G-M approved".

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MCN
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Join Date: Jan 2014
Posts: 3479

06-18-2015, 08:33 AM #47

The whole GM-approval thing is really a non-issue. The God Machine does give angels Missions to accomplish, yes. They don't have a choice but to try and fulfill the mission (or rebel and Fall, but that's another matter; for a familiar, I'm assuming we're not going to Fall and not be a spirit anymore).

However, the angels are given complete and utter discretion on the best way to accomplish said mission. That discretion is actually their raison d'etre - they're needed to think on human scale. And, don't forget, angels still need something to provide essence and prevent bleed. A mage can do both, freeing up the angel in its mission, as well as a potential ally. If an angel feels that becoming a familiar would allow it to achieve its Mission more successfully, then I don't think there's anything stopping it.

I'll have to look more in detail at the familiar rules when we get them, but a

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number of potential reasons for becoming a familiar includes greater mobility, extra help, and an additional essence source separate from the Infrastructure sacrifices. Indeed, the angel might become a familiar simply because its Infrastructure or supporting cult are gone and it won't abandon its Mission.

EDIT - plus, there's the option of low rank Exiles here, as well.

Anyways, my point is just that there's a lot of options going on here, and it'll make one hell of a plot hook and a great source of mysteries for any character interested, especially any Obrimos. I'm already thinking of ways that the whole Truth angle of Prime would work when used with the hidden Gears.

Last edited by MCN; 06-18-2015, 08:52 AM.

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Freemind
Member

Join Date: Apr 2014
Posts: 1333

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06-18-2015, 09:34 AM #48

Oh, agreed. I just was originally thinking about how the Angel might refuse a familiar pact if it would have to go off mission. But those are all great points

The one thing I wonder is what happens if the Angel gets recalled or the familiar pact gets in the way of their mission (was once needed, but no longer is)? Other Familiars don't have split loyalties, and I can see this potentially leading to some Falls.

Last edited by Freemind; 06-18-2015, 09:42 AM.

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MCN
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06-18-2015, 09:56 AM #49

> *Originally posted by **Freemind***
> *The one thing I wonder is what happens if the Angel gets recalled or the familiar pact gets in the way of their mission (was once needed, but no longer is)? Other Familiars don't have split loyalties, and I can see this potentially leading to some Falls.*

Well, that's not quite true, about the split loyalties, that is. Ghosts are defined pretty much by their method of death and unfinished businesses / lingering emotions. Avenging their death is a common motivation for ghosts, and that may easily clash with the needs of the Awakened "master." And being recalled for an angel would likely be equivalent to moving on with a ghost. Spirits, on the other hand, don't quite have a "mission complete" status like the others, but they do have the spirit courts they belong to. Higher ranked spirits can boss them around for another conflict of interests. Can't comment on goetic familiars; not enough info.

In any case, there's a lot of potential for different stories here. But, in the case of an angel, I don't think there's the option of disobeying here. Its life as a familiar is

over either way - either fall and become a Demon, or break the familiar pact and follow orders. Mind you, the familiar pact likely included a stipulation on helping with the Mission in the first place, so if the mage refuses to help with the Mission, then the pact's been broken anyways.

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Freemind
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06-18-2015, 10:04 AM #50

True. It is just in thr case of ghosts and spirits, at least in 1e, most of those conflicts were subsumed into the familiar pact: Ghosts no longer need their fetters, and regain some of true personality rather than just have their fixations, while spirits are happy to have a source of essence and be safe, and have part of their nature redefined so as to be supported as a familiar. While there may be conflicts, the Mage is their central loyalty (or at the very least, they potentially have the powers usually to *make* their familiar do what the mage needs). The GM angels don't have that: thr Mage is secondary to the GM, and the mage can't overcome that.

And while I am sure the pact would contain that, it would likely only extend to that mission (I dont think mages would agree to anything too open ended). If the next mission was "now kill the mage"... things could get dicey.

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MCN
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Join Date: Jan 2014
Posts: 3479

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06-18-2015, 10:42 AM #51

I'm going to have to disagree. In one of DaveB's actual play threads, one of the character's had a cat familiar that served as a spy to others; they ultimately had to kill the familiar. There's nothing about the familiar bond that innately forces the familiar to be subservient or loyal to the mage. Generally, most players will have a loyal familiar, due to the idea that, as a merit, its a part of that character. As well, most of the time? The needs and drama of the Hisil's spirit courts play second string to the needs of Awakened society in the game*.

On the other hand, take an infernal demon for example. While they generally will follow along with the "master," you know that the demon will try to tempt you, or pervert your will in an evil way, or twist your orders. Its part of the understanding when you take a demon for a familiar. Their ultimate loyalty is NOT to the magician that bonded with them. I don't think anyone other than the most hubristic summoner would ever think otherwise.

Likewise, anyone who takes an angel for a familiar would have to operate under the understanding of that angels are ultimately loyal to God above all else. Its just such a common understanding, I don't think that anyone but the most hubristic would think otherwise.

Mages agreeing to anything open ended? Just take a look at the Seers for open ended blind faith worship. Its more than possible. As for a Mission of "kill the mage?" First, I'd say that was a nasty move on the ST's part, unless part of a dramatic plot - the GM tends to call for deaths as part of an occult matrix; otherwise, it'd just say "prevent XYZ from happening." Secondly, the God Machine is well known for taking good care of those who serve in its Missions, seeing them as effective tools. Third, most angels are recalled, not given multiple

Missions one after another.

Now, I'm not saying that there aren't some issues involved if we just look at Random Angel X. Many angels won't be appropriate, but a number with certain qualities (likely selected by the ST and player jointly) will be fine. Long term Missions that will include the length of play, or one tied into the main plot, will be fairly common, I'd imagine. Perhaps the mission could be something as beneficial as "Kill scelesti infestation in city" even. The God Machine wants to maintain the status quo of secrecy, but the status quo also involves keeping things from getting *worse* by spreading more Abyssal anti-love.

* I consider Mage to be as much of a crossover game as Beast and Hunter are. Unlike the latter two, however, Mage doesn't primarily deal with other PC splats, either as friends or foes. Rather, mage tend to studying other realms and ephemeral beings that feature strongly in other lines. Most notably Faerie/Hedge, the Underworld, etc.

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Strill
Member

Join Date: Nov 2013
Posts: 1261

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06-18-2015, 10:46 AM #52

> *Originally posted by **MCN***
> *There's nothing about the familiar bond that innately forces the familiar to be subservient or loyal to the mage*

Yes there is. If the familiar betrays the mage, they can suck all of its essence away from any distance and starve it.

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Elfive
Member

Join Date: Jun 2014
Posts: 8226

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06-18-2015, 10:57 AM #53

They said *innately*. The threat of essence drain is a strong motivator, but that only means the familiar will do it's best to not get caught.

Not that we can be sure that's even a thing any more.

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MCN
Member

Join Date: Jan 2014
Posts: 3479

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06-18-2015, 11:08 AM #54

> *Originally posted by* ***Strill***
> *Yes there is. If the familiar betrays the mage, they can suck all of its essence away from any distance and starve it.*

Even as a threat, that's not exactly an unfailing motivation. If we're talking about a ghost familiar running across its killer and going to take revenge against the wishes of the mage, chances are it'll take action even if the mage does suck the ghost dry. And, as Elfive said, we're not sure if that's a thing anymore; new rules, and all.

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Freemind
Member

Join Date: Apr 2014
Posts: 1333

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06-18-2015, 11:19 AM #55

First, there are exceptions to spirits and ghosts as loyal. Don't get me wrong. My point was that in a majority of cases, they will be loyal to their Mage, and vice versa. The benefits of the familiar pact are enough for both parties to not want to violate the others trust, though there is nothing preventing that from happening. That said, GM Angles are never truly loyal, or at least never more than they are to the GM. And unlike ghosts and spirits where you can use magic to force commands and assume direct control, Angels cannot be controlled this way due to the GM. So while your spirit familiar might get uppity, you can always reign it in if you have the proper training in spirit. Even infernal demons are susceptible, and you can even edit their nature with enough dots in Spirit to make them no longer a pain in your ass. The angel will just ignore you.

And you are making a big assumption about how much mages know about the GM and its Angels. Is it common knowledge? Do they know that the Angels are more than spirits without looking into it? I would assume most mages would try and get some info, but others might not (especially newer mages). I agree Mage is great at crossover, but even with all their tricks, they don't know *everything* there is to know. The fact that the angel might not bother to explain itself or feel that doing so could compromise their mission might add to this issue. I could definitely see mages being naive or hubristic enough to take on a powerful familiar without really looking at the fine print.

Also, the Exarchs aren't spirits or ghosts. It is like saying that a person and a dogs relationship is akin to a person and God or the President: the power dynamics are strikingly different, which in turn means the interactions will be different. The Seers do openly agree to *serve* the Exarchs, which is understandable when you feel they rule reality, but this is also not portrayed as a good thing nor is it akin to the relationship that has been portrayed in familiar pacts.

And yeah, so let's say that instead of changing missions the Mage doesn't realize the originals full extent ("destruction of supernatural threats" may include people the Mage doesn't view as a threat, for example). And it still doesn't address what happens when the mission is completed.

I am not against GM angel pacts, I just feel that the Angels natures are going to make them a rare and complicated occurrence.

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MCN
Member

Join Date: Jan 2014
Posts: 3479

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06-18-2015, 11:48 AM #56

> *Originally posted by **Freemind***
> *First, there are exceptions to spirits and ghosts as loyal. Don't get me wrong. My point was that in a majority of cases, they will be loyal to their Mage, and vice versa. The benefits of the familiar pact are enough for both parties to not want to violate the others trust, though there is nothing preventing that from happening. That said, GM Angles are never truly loyal, or at least never more than they are to the GM.*

According to the **God Machine Chronicle** book, the God Machine understands loyalty. If someone helps complete its Missions, it usually rewards their helpers, so long as they continue to follow. This is the basis of angelic cults.

So, while the angel is ultimately loyal to the God Machine, its not like the God Machine is going to be casually screwing over the mage either, so long as the Mission it assigned is completed. I don't see any reason for conditional loyalty to be an issue. Not unless the mage expects a blindly obedient slave, and, as far as I'm aware, the familiar bond still requires mutual consent to establish.

> *And unlike ghosts and spirits where you can use magic to force commands and assume direct control, Angels cannot be controlled this way due to the GM. So while your spirit familiar might get uppity, you can always reign it in if you have the proper training in spirit.*

To an extent. A Mission is sacrosanct - you can't change that. I don't recall hearing that absolutely nothing can affect an angel, however.

> *Even infernal demons are susceptible, and you can even edit their nature with enough dots in Spirit to make them no longer a pain in your ass. The angel will just ignore you.*

Fairly sure they are not. "Dominions are no mere elementals, thought-forms or hateful ghosts. Their Secret Names, power and guile make them immune to magical compulsion. Spells can injure them and protect people against demonic attacks, but when it comes to summoning Dominions, mages must use the same rites as Sleepers." So, while you can deal with tainted ghosts or spirits as normal, true demons are beyond magical control.

> *Originally posted by **Freemind***
> *And you are making a big assumption about how much mages know about the GM and its Angels. Is it common knowledge?*

Is it common knowledge that angels obey God above all else? *slow blink* I mean, that's the only in-game assumption I'm making, and I think that's something pretty much anyone would agree on, simply because its general knowledge. Everything else I'm talking about from a meta-game design level.

> *Do they know that the Angels are more than spirits without looking into it?*

I imagine that simple Mage Sight would reveal it. Especially since you'll likely need appropriate Arcana to even SEE an angel clearly in the first place. Spirit doesn't let you get a clear image of goetics or ghosts, after all.

> *I would assume most mages would try and get some info, but others might not (especially newer mages). I agree Mage is great at crossover, but even with all their tricks, they don't know everything there is to know.*

Setting aside that the Mysterium likely has books on angels (its a fairly common Library option even for human occultists), I never said the mages knew any of the stuff we were talking about. I'm talking about things the ST should know that's in the books.

> *The fact that the angel might not bother to explain itself or feel that doing so could compromise their mission might add to this issue. I could definitely see mages being naive or hubristic enough to take on a powerful familiar without really looking at the fine print.*
>
> *Also, the Exarchs aren't spirits or ghosts.*

Only brought the Exarchs up to showcase that, yes, Mages are just as prone to blind faith or taking open ended deals as the next person. There's nothing special about mages in that regard. They're as failible as the next person. Which, you're now agreeing with me on?

> *And yeah, so let's say that instead of changing missions the Mage doesn't realize the originals full extent ("destruction of supernatural threats" may include people the Mage doesn't view as a threat, for example). And it still doesn't address what happens when the mission is completed.*

This is actually covered in **Demon** and **God Machine Chronicle.** Angels are designed to be specialists, made to accomplish this one Mission they're given. The GM doesn't change Missions - succeed or fail, the angel returns or is recalled, and a new angel (or an upgraded, memory wiped version of the same one) is sent out for the next mission.

A mage might not know that's how angels work, but the ST running the angel definitely should know that OOC. Likely, the mage's player should as well, if they're getting an angelic familiar. The PC can be clueless, but I don't think a player or ST should be.

> *I am not against GM angel pacts, I just feel that the Angels natures are going to make them a rare and complicated occurrence.*

That's fine, but PCs aren't most people, and they pretty define "rare and complicated." And that's all I was really focusing on. I consider goetic or ghostly familiars to be very rare as well.

Last edited by MCN; 06-18-2015, 12:14 PM.

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Freemind
Member

Join Date: Apr 2014
Posts: 1333

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06-18-2015, 12:29 PM #57

Considering that the GM doesn't come across as being commonly known to mages, based off the Demon and GMC material, I don think it is unfair to ask if most mages would get the nature of Angels and their relation to the GM. I know that we all know it, but my question is that do A) mages commonly know about the GM? B) they understand the full nature of the GM and its Angels? I could see those without a lot of insight just viewing the GM as a powerful spirit and the Angels as members of their court. I am not saying mages can't find out the info (they are mages, after all, and as you pointed out, the resources exist evenly mundane lay) but there is a difference between "knowledge is out there, and I could potentially find it" and "I know it". And as for Mage sight, Goetic demons and Ghosts are different because they are governed by completely different arcana. I will admit, I don't recall exactly where the Angels fall but aren't they usually described as spirits? So wouldn't they appear to the Mage Sight using Spirit?

And the Exarchs are not blind faith: they are known to exist, known to be powerful forces in the Supernal, and are known to influence the Fallen World. What they are might be up to debate (gods, ancient mages, etc.) but Dave has pointed out repeatedly that their existence and power are known factors. The only real blind faith that Seers have is that the Exarchs will let them ascend, and even that can have evidence offered via the Ministers and Tetrarchs. The point I made originally was that a familiar bond is at most between equals in most cases, if not one where the Mage (at least thinks) he has the upper hand, and knows he is working with a non-human force with alien elements. Such a relationship is one where you aren't going to open yourself up to being in the subservient role. Serving the Exarchs is different, as they are the dominant power in any negotiation and either don't need you enough or will crush you if you don't agree to their terms. I mean, there is a reason you can't have high ranking spirits or ghosts: a rank 5 spirit is like trying to make a Small god your personal buddy.

I don't think the player or ST should be clueless either, but then that raises why a player would want an Angel Familiar if they understand that helping it in its mission means it leaves, or that it will never be working with him outside just their mission and service to the GM.

And yes, players are usually the exceptions. And like I said, I overall think it is okay to have in a game, if everyone is on the same page. But it also is something where the distinctions must be drawn that Angels are far different than any other type of familiar.

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Freemind
Member

Join Date: Apr 2014
Posts: 1333

06-18-2015, 12:36 PM #58

And I just want to be clear: I am totally fine with Angels as Pacts and overall agree with the general theme of your ideas @MCN. I simply think that anything dealing with the GM is going to be much more complicated than many of the other aspects of the Fallen World.

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Leliel
Member

Join Date: Nov 2013
Posts: 2259

06-18-2015, 05:37 PM #59

> *Originally posted by **ZealousChristian24***
> *Well, that just means that It just wanted that servitor unit to bond with you. Of course, that's not exactly the most reassuring option...*

Achievement Unlocked: Mari0net1e

Becom-er, *Gain* an angelic familiar.

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Draca
Member

Join Date: Jun 2015
Posts: 82

06-21-2015, 12:48 PM #60

> *Originally posted by **Freemind***
> *And as for Mage sight, Goetic demons and Ghosts are different because they are governed by completely different arcana. I will admit, I don't recall exactly where the Angels fall but aren't they usually described as spirits? So wouldn't they appear to the Mage Sight using Spirit?*

I believe I read somewhere that Angels are affected by Prime so I would assume you need Prime's Mage Sight in order to see them properly

Last edited by Draca; 06-21-2015, 02:53 PM.

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